when everything is clicking like it is today, that they can't hear me running in, that they are only guessing at when I am arriving, as if there is nothing there. This is one of those times, where my run-up leaves no trace. The last step before the wicket, I am landing again on my left foot, this time turning almost completely side on, followed by a skip to take flight.

As I'm waiting to land on my right foot, just beyond the waiting umpire who stands stationary next to me, a kind of immovable waxwork point of reference, it all happens. I am coiled as a spring, left knee is in flight, bent and reaching my chest. I can see the wristband on my left hand move past my nose; in the early years it was a watch and now it's a white band. It shows me where the target is, allowing me to line up my right arm as it follows, joining the ball and that callus with the ball in the hand. The ball is not held tight. I can feel how loose it is for a moment, totally relaxed, almost like I could let it go and drop it, before it unwinds out of the coil, something rhythmical with it, the closest I will ever get to dancing.

As I land to deliver the ball, my right foot first lands at the same, strange angle it always has. They tried to re-model my action in 2004 to make it safer, but I decided to veto it after my stress fracture in 2006, going back to what I know, to all the natural idiosyncrasies. It's only on landing here that I re-feel my body and all the pain and history of damage. The spur, for example, that sticks out at the back of my right ankle as it does, the one that broke into quite a few little pieces and that I have had injected with steroids to ease the inflammation ever since. Then, as I reach to deliver, I recall in muscle memory the South African tour where I landed with such intensity, so often, that the muscle tugged at the rib until it snapped and broke a rib. As my arm goes over, I remember the time I had dived for a ball and landed on my armpit, jarring the shoulder. The broken fingers, the multiple calf tears, the groin that kept me out of an entire Ashes series. They are all there as I land, the memory of each of them. No England cricketer has ever had more injury records, the physio tells me.

As I let go, the ball shapes exactly where I want it to go. The magic ball. It travels towards the leg stump, causing Josh Da Silva to motion to hit it square, just like McCullum did, before doing the impossible thing that I have almost awed myself with over the years, straightening dramatically and catching the outside edge, Da Silva turned inside out.